showed the Trinamool, AIADMK and Biju Janata Dal doing strongly, but not in a position to be kingmakers.

The real kingmaker, it seemed, was Amit Shah. Most polls were giving the BJP fifty or more seats from the decisive battleground state of Uttar Pradesh. Shah came on our programme that night once the findings were out. 'Your poll has underestimated us slightly. My final number is 295 to 305 for the NDA,' he claimed in his trademark no-nonsense style. I asked him if he was willing to put a wager on it. '*Rajdeepji, yeh sab chodiye, hum 16 May ko baarah baje baat karenge!'* (Forget about bet and all that, we will speak on 16 May at 12 noon).

Frankly, I agreed with Shah's assessment. I had argued with our statistician, Dr Rajeeva Karandikar of the Chennai Mathematical Institute, that maybe we should be edging the NDA closer to the 300-seat mark. 'Rajeeva, if the BJP is getting 40 per cent votes in UP, they will sweep the state,' was my argument. Rajeeva, a brilliant statistical mind, wanted to be a little careful. 'I agree, but maybe sometimes it is better to be cautious,' was his advice. Perhaps we erred on the side of caution because the ghosts of 2004 were haunting all of us.

They certainly weren't haunting Shah. The politician who had first predicted that the Modi wave was becoming a tsunami was ready to have the last laugh.

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Within hours of the exit poll results being announced, all roads led to Gandhinagar. Fellow politicians, bureaucrats, industrialists and well-wishers were all keen to have a word with the man who was set to become the country's next prime minister. But, as was typical of him, Modi met very few visitors. He had always kept a sparse house—it's a home with minimal furniture—and he didn't want to be flooded with bouquets and garlands. At least, not yet.

Among the first to call on him had been Gadkari who had flown down from Delhi for what was being described as a 'courtesy call'. Within the